

立命館大学 英語 過去問風演習

長文読解 ー 本番想定 (大問 1 題・25 分)

2026年5月26日

高校3年～既卒 (立命館大学 文系志望)

英語 (長文読解・立命館本番レベル)

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Reading Comprehension (25 min, 30 pts) [配点 30 点]

Read the following passage and answer the questions.

In recent years, the phrase "the loneliness epidemic" has entered public discourse. Surveys across developed countries report rising levels of social isolation, particularly among young adults and the elderly. (A) In 2023, the U.S. Surgeon General declared loneliness a public health crisis, comparing its effects on mortality to smoking fifteen cigarettes a day.

How did loneliness become an epidemic? Several forces converged. Urban living, longer commutes, and dispersed families weakened traditional community structures. The decline of religious participation, civic organizations, and neighborhood institutions removed venues where people once forged bonds. (B) Social media, paradoxically, has often deepened isolation rather than alleviated it: scrolling through other people's curated lives can leave us feeling more alone, not less.

The health consequences are striking. Loneliness has been linked to increased risks of heart disease, dementia, depression, and premature death. The biological mechanisms are not fully understood, but chronic loneliness appears to elevate stress hormones, weaken immune function, and disrupt sleep. (C) Humans evolved as deeply social animals, and prolonged isolation appears to register in the body as a kind of sustained physiological threat.

Some societies have responded with policy innovations. The United Kingdom appointed a Minister for Loneliness in 2018. Japan followed in 2021. Local programs pair isolated seniors with volunteers, support community gardens, and fund "social prescribing" — doctors recommending art classes or walking groups rather than only medication.

Individual responses also matter. Researchers emphasize the difference between solitude — chosen and refreshing — and loneliness — unwanted and corrosive. Building meaningful connection requires effort: showing up consistently, listening carefully, and tolerating the awkwardness of vulnerability. In a culture that prizes productivity and self-sufficiency, these are radical acts.

Notes:

epidemic — 流行病・蔓延

civic — 市民の・公共の

social prescribing — 社会的処方

solitude — 孤独 (自ら選ぶ静かな時間)

Reading Comprehension (25 min, 30 pts) — Questions

Q1

1

What striking comparison is made in underlined sentence (A)?

- ① Loneliness causes more deaths than all diseases combined.
- ② The mortality effect of loneliness is comparable to smoking 15 cigarettes a day.
- ③ Loneliness is less harmful than smoking.
- ④ Cigarettes cause loneliness.

Q2

2

According to underlined sentence (B), what is paradoxical about social media?

- ① It connects people more deeply than any prior technology.
- ② It is free and accessible.
- ③ It has often deepened isolation rather than alleviated it.
- ④ It has eliminated all loneliness.

Q3

3

Which is NOT mentioned as a force contributing to the loneliness epidemic?

- ① Urban living and longer commutes
- ② Decline of religious and civic participation
- ③ Dispersed families
- ④ Mandatory community service programs

Q4

4

What does underlined sentence (C) suggest about prolonged isolation?

- ① It has no effect on the body.
- ② The body registers it as a sustained physiological threat, since humans evolved as social animals.
- ③ It makes people physically stronger.
- ④ It is only a psychological issue with no biological effects.

Q5

5

Which countries appointed a Minister for Loneliness?

- ① The United States in 2010
- ② United Kingdom (2018) and Japan (2021)
- ③ France and Germany in 2015
- ④ No country has done so.

Q6

6

What distinction do researchers emphasize?

- ① Between male and female loneliness
- ② Between solitude (chosen and refreshing) and loneliness (unwanted and corrosive)
- ③ Between online and offline activity
- ④ Between rich and poor loneliness

解答・解説

問	解答	解説
1	②	【正解】 ② 下線部 (A) 「comparing its effects on mortality to smoking fifteen cigarettes a day」と一致。
2	③	【正解】 ③ 下線部 (B) 「Social media, paradoxically, has often deepened isolation rather than alleviated it」と一致。
3	④	【正解】 ④ 第2段落で挙げられる要因: 都市生活・宗教/市民組織衰退・家族分散・SNS。 「mandatory community service」は記述なし。
4	②	【正解】 ② 下線部 (C) 「Humans evolved as deeply social animals, and prolonged isolation appears to register in the body as a kind of sustained physiological threat」と一致。
5	②	【正解】 ② 第4段落 「The United Kingdom appointed a Minister for Loneliness in 2018. Japan followed in 2021」と一致。
6	②	【正解】 ② 最終段落 「the difference between solitude — chosen and refreshing — and loneliness — unwanted and corrosive」と一致。